

Snowy owl

Few predatory birds are found as far north as the snowy owl. Many other owl species live in cold northern forests, but only the snowy can survive on the treeless tundra, where the ground is frozen solid and covered in snow for much of the year.

Ground nester

Unlike other owls, the snowy owl must nest on the ground in its open tundra habitat. It chooses an elevated site to give it a view of approaching danger.

Variable clutch

The number of eggs a snowy owl lays depends upon how much food is available. When there are plenty of prey animals to hunt, the owl may lay eight or more.

Non-breeding range

Snowy owls breed in the northerly parts of their range and migrate further south during the winter. They will also sometimes move south at other times if food becomes scarce.

ANIMALS IN DANGER

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⚠️ IUCN status: vulnerable

👤 Population estimate: 28,000

Blending in

The snowy owl is the only owl with an all-white plumage. This helps disguise it against the snowy ground, especially during the Arctic summer when there is almost continuous daylight and the bird is breeding and hunts at all hours.



Hunting

The snowy owl has such good hearing it can detect the position of prey burrowing beneath a blanket of snow. It swallows small rodents whole, but will tear larger animals, such as hares and rabbits, to pieces first.

